

1. What is a Robot?

Core Definition: An electromechanical system characterized by three essential traits:

- **Reprogrammable** Flexible software control
- **Multifunctional** Versatile multi-task capability
- **Sensible** Real-time environment awareness

Key Terminology:

- **Robot:** Physical mechanism performing human tasks autonomously or via teleoperation.
- **Robotics:** Science of mechanical design, kinematics, control & software.
- **Telerobotics:** Remote-controlled operation in extreme/hazardous environments.

2. Automation vs. Robots

Fixed Automation

- **Single dedicated task**
- Maximum speed & efficiency
- Rigid; high retooling cost
- Ex: Bottling line, dishwasher

Flexible Robots

- **Diverse multiple tasks**
- Reprogrammable motions
- High mechanical flexibility
- Ex: 6-DOF arms, AGVs, CNCs

3. Asimov's 3 Laws of Robotics

- 1 **Safety First:** May not injure a human or, through inaction, allow harm.
- 2 **Obedience:** Must obey human orders, **except** when conflicting with Law 1.
- 3 **Self-Defense:** Must protect own existence, unless conflicting with Laws 1 or 2.

4. Core Hardware Architecture

- Sensors** **Data Input:** Internal state (encoders, resolvers) & external world (cameras, LIDAR, tactile/touch).
- Controller** **The 'Brain':** Executes trajectories, computes kinematics & closes real-time feedback loops.
- Actuators** **The 'Muscles':** Convert electrical/fluid energy into physical movement (servos, steppers, pneumatics).

5. Robot Types & Applications

Mechanical Architectures:

- **Manipulators:** Serial arms (Articulated, SCARA, Cartesian).
- **Mobile & Wheeled:** Differential drive, Omni, AGVs.
- **Legged:** Bipedal, quadrupeds, hexapods.
- **Autonomous Vehicles:** AUVs (Underwater), UAVs (Aerial drones).

Primary Drivers (3 D's / U's):

- Dangerous** Nuclear cleanup, bomb disposal.
- Dull / Repetitive** High-speed assembly, spot welding.
- Dirty / Unwanted** Sewer inspection, toilet cleaning.

6. Robot Programming Methods

ON-LINE METHODS (At the Robot)

- **Teach Pendant:** Handheld button box. Jog arm to waypoints & save; controller calculates PTP paths.
- **Lead-Through:** Manually guide arm by hand. Records continuous stream (60–80 pts/sec; high memory).

OFF-LINE METHODS (Remote / Code)

- **Programming Languages:** Text code (AML, VAL, RobotStudio) without halting factory line.
- **Task-Level:** High-level goals ("pick item A") auto-compiled into trajectory commands.

7. Performance Metrics

- **Working Volume:** 3D envelope reachable by end-effector.
- **Speed & Accel:** Motion rate; trade-off with precision & payload.
- **Resolution:** Smallest commandable incremental step.
- **Accuracy:** Closeness between **commanded target** and **actual reached position** ($|x_{\text{target}} - x_{\text{actual}}|$).
- **Repeatability:** Ability to return to the **exact same point** over repeated cycles (σ).

HIGH-YIELD EXAM DISTINCTION

Accuracy vs. Repeatability: A robot can have **High Repeatability** (hits the identical spot 100 times in a row) but **Low Accuracy** (that spot is systematically 2 cm off target)!

1. Sensing & Transduction

- **Sensing:** Collecting information about the world.
- **Sensor:** Device mapping physical/chemical phenomena to quantitative signals.
- **Transduction Principle:** Converting one energy form into another.

Sensor Type	Transduction Mechanism
Thermistor	Temp → Resistance (R)
Photodiode	Light → Current (I)
Pyroelectric	Thermal rad. → Voltage (V)
Humidity	Moisture → Capacitance (C)
LVDT	Position → Inductance (L)
Microphone	Sound press. → Elect. signal

2. Sensor Classifications

State Focus:

- **Proprioceptive** (Internal): Measures internal parameters (joint angle, wheel position, battery, tachometers/encoders/accelerometers).
- **Exteroceptive** (External): Environment & objects (proximity, vision, range).

Energy Interaction:

- **Active:** Emits energy & reads reflection (Sonar, Radar, Modulated IR, LiDAR).
- **Passive:** Receives ambient energy only (Cameras, Pyroelectric, LDR).

Contact & Modality:

- **Contact / Non-contact:** Touch (bumpers) vs. remote (optical, ultrasonic).
- **Visual / Non-visual:** Vision cameras vs. non-optical sensors.

3. Contact & Resistive Sensors

A. FEELERS (TACTILE/CONTACT)

- **Whiskers:** Piano wire in metal hoop; deflection closes circuit; binary (0/1) output.
- **Bumpers & Guards:** Frame on microswitches; collision triggers switch; binary (0/1) output.

B. RESISTIVE (VARIABLE R)

- **Bend Sensors:** Flexible strips where R increases as bent ($10\text{ k}\Omega - 35\text{ k}\Omega$). *Uses:* Joint angles, wall-following, loads.
- **Potentiometers:** Linear/rotational variable resistors tracking sliding parts or rotating joint shafts.
- **Photocells (CdS / LDR):** Resistance shifts with light; highly non-linear, ideal for light tracking.

4. Capacitive vs. Inductive Sensors

Capacitive (All Materials)

- Measures change in **dielectric**
- Detects **metals & non-metals** (liquids, plastics, powders)
- Senses through glass/plastic
- Sensitive to dust & humidity

APPLICATIONS

- **Level Detection:** Liquid/grains
- **Proximity:** Assembly lines
- **Touch Sensing:** Touchscreens

Inductive (Metals Only)

- Emits AC magnetic field; senses **eddy currents**
- Detects **metals ONLY**
- Max on **ferrous** (iron/steel)
- Immune to oil, dust & water

APPLICATIONS

- **Position:** Metal part automation
- **Speed:** Rotating gears/shafts
- **Metal Detection:** Safety

5. Infrared (IR) Sensor Types

Type	Principle & Trade-offs	Applications
Intensity-Based Reflective	• Measures reflected light • Pro Cheap, simple • Con Ambient & color sensitive	• Line-following • Wall-tracking • Break-beams
Modulated IR Proximity	• Flashes at $32 - 45\text{ kHz}$ • Receiver demodulates signal • Pro Immune to ambient light	• Proximity sensing • Remote controls • Obstacle avoidance
IR Triangulation PSD Ranger	• Emitter + lens + PSD • Angle of return gives range • Pro Color & light immune	• Sharp GP2D02 ($10 - 80\text{ cm}$) • Distance map

6. Ultrasonic Sensors & Noise

- **Principle:** Ultrasound burst ($\approx 50\text{ kHz}$). Time-of-Flight (t):

$$D = v \cdot t \Rightarrow d = \frac{v \cdot t}{2} \quad (v \approx 340\text{ m/s in air})$$

- **Limitations:**
 - **Bearing Uncertainty:** Wide beam spread (opening arc $\approx 30^\circ$).
 - **Speed Latency:** Sound is slow (e.g. 30 m round-trip takes $\approx 200\text{ ms}$).
- **Noise Issues:** Acoustic noise & sensor crosstalk.

7. Laser Range Finders (LiDAR)

- **Performance:** Long range ($2\text{ m} - 500\text{ m}$), high resolution (10 mm), fast scans ($13 - 40\text{ ms}$).
- **Robustness:** Narrow beam; immune to ambient light & specular reflections.

HIGH-YIELD EXAM COMPARISON

Inductive vs. Capacitive: Inductive senses **metals only**; Capacitive senses **all materials** (dielectric shift).

Ultrasonic vs. LiDAR: Sonar has wide **bearing uncertainty** ($\approx 30^\circ$) & latency; LiDAR provides millimeter angular precision.

1. Agency & Marr's 3-Level Theory

- **Agency:** Capacity of an entity (human or robot) to act intentionally, make choices, & exert control over actions and outcomes.
- **David Marr's Framework:** Analyzes information systems across 3 empirical levels:

Level	Question / Focus	Search & Rescue Robot Example
L1: Comp.	What goal / problem is solved?	Locate trapped survivors in low-visibility
L2: Algo.	What processes / IO represent it?	Steer toward heat & CO ₂ gradients
L3: Impl.	How physically realized in hardware?	Angle vectors to heat centroids; wheel motors

KEY EXAM CONCEPT L1 & L2 are abstract & identical across biology/robots. Distinction appears only at Level 3.

2. Bio-Inspired Robotic Mappings

Biological Model	Robotic Mapping	Mechanism
Bat Echolocation	Obstacle Avoidance	Echo delay detection (ultrasonic)
Ant Foraging	Swarm Pathfinding	Ant Colony Optim. (ACO), digital pheromones
Bird Flocking	Coordinated Drone Swarm	Reynolds Boids: alignment, cohesion, separation
Frog Tongue	Fast Grasping Arm	High-speed camera + snatch reflex
Cuttlefish	Adaptive Camouflage	Pattern mapping onto E-skin

3. Classifications of Behavior

- **Behavior Definition:** Direct mapping of sensory inputs to motor actions to accomplish a task.
- **1. REFLEXIVE (STIMULUS-RESPONSE / S-R)**
 - Hardwired neural/electronic circuits for fastest execution:
 - **Reflexes:** Response lasts **only as long as stimulus** & is proportional to intensity (e.g. knee-jerk, pupillary light reflex).
 - **Taxes (Taxis):** Directional orientation / movement relative to stimulus:
 - *Tropotaxis:* Sea turtles navigating toward moonlit ocean.
 - *Negative Phototaxis:* Earthworms crawling away from light.
 - *Positive Rheotaxis:* Salmon swimming upstream against flow.
 - **Fixed-Action Patterns (FAP):** Response **persists longer** than triggering stimulus (e.g. spider web weaving, squirrels caching nuts, duckling imprinting).
- **2. REACTIVE BEHAVIORS**
 - Learned skills executed automatically without conscious processing (e.g. riding a bicycle).
- **3. CONSCIOUS BEHAVIORS**
 - Deliberate, planned actions coordinating multiple sub-behaviors.

4. Schema Theory & OOP Robotics

- **Schema:** Foundational OOP template used for the **Reactive Layer** of autonomous robots.
- **Components of a Behavior Schema:**
 - **Perceptual Schema** Sensory feature extraction, threshold filtering & stimulus delays.
 - **Motor Schema** Computational procedure to produce physical action/movement vector.
- **Schema Instantiation (SI):** Creating a concrete runtime instance from a generic parameterized class template (e.g. applying specific handlebar height & seat position to a bike-riding schema).

5. Vector Action & S-R Notation

Mathematical Formulations:

$$\{B : S \rightarrow R\} \quad \text{or} \quad B[S] = R$$

- *S*: Perceptual function converting raw sensor feeds to **percept**.
- *R*: Motor function converting percept into physical **action**.
- *B*: Overarching behavioral system.

Vector Field Combination:

- Directional stimuli (e.g. left & right eyes) are converted to vectors and combined via **Vector Summation** (Σ) to determine the resultant motor command:

$$V_{\text{resultant}} = v_{\text{left}} + v_{\text{right}}$$

EXAM HIGHLIGHTS: LECTURE 03

Reflex vs. FAP Duration: Reflex stops as soon as stimulus stops; FAP continues for longer duration.

Taxis Examples: Positive Rheotaxis (salmon upstream), Tropotaxis (sea turtles to moonlight), Negative Phototaxis (earthworms).

Marr's Level 3: L1 & L2 are identical in biology & robotics; differences emerge **only at Level 3**.

1. LEGO Mindstorms EV3 Architecture

- **Processing Unit:** ARM9 @ 300 MHz, 16 MB Flash, 64 MB RAM.
- **Operating System:** Embedded Linux-based OS.
- **Sensor Ports (1-4):** 4 Input ports supporting Analog & high-speed Digital UART up to 460.8 kbit/s.
- **Motor Ports (A-D):** 4 Output ports with built-in optical rotation encoders for position/speed feedback.
- **I/O & Expansion:**
 - High-speed USB (480 Mbit/s) + Host daisy-chaining (up to 3 levels), WiFi dongle, & USB storage.
 - Micro SD-card slot (supports up to 32 GB).
- **Display & UI:** 178 × 128 monochrome LCD matrix, 6 backlit navigation/debugging buttons.
- **Wireless Comms:** Bluetooth v2.1 + EDR, Apple/Android smart device protocol.

2. Platform Generations & Modules

Platform	CPU / OS	Key Ports & Features
RCX (1998)	Hitachi H8	3 In / 3 Out; Optical IR tower comms
NXT (2006)	ARM7 + AVR	4 In / 3 Out; Bluetooth, 100 × 64 LCD
EV3 (2013)	ARM9 Linux	4 In / 4 Out; Daisy-chain, USB Host, SD

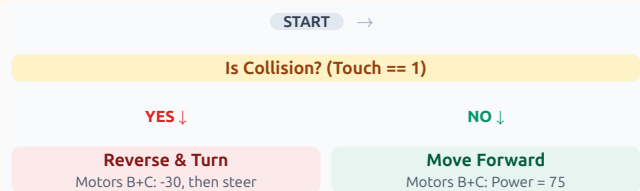
Sensor & Actuator Modules:

- **Motors:** Large (high torque) & Medium (high RPM) with integrated tacho-encoders.
- **Sensors:** Touch (binary limit), Color (ambient/reflected/RGB), IR Seeker/Beacon, Ultrasonic.

3. Step 1: Avoid Collision (Reflex)

PURE REFLEXIVE BEHAVIOR

- **Objective:** Move continuously; instantly back up and pivot when a physical impact occurs.

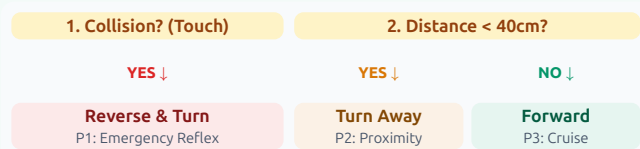


- **Collision == True:** Reverse (−30, 2 rot) → steer turn (−45/30, 2 rot).
- Direct hardware-to-motor S-R loop without state memory.

4. Step 2: Collision + Obstacle Avoidance

HIERARCHICAL PRIORITY ARBITRATION

- Combines contact (Touch) and non-contact (Proximity/Force) into a 2-tier reactive hierarchy:

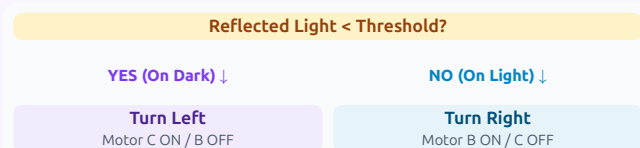


- **P1 (Touch):** Emergency physical recovery (overrides all).
- **P2 (Proximity):** Smooth steering turn away before contact.
- **P3 (Default):** Drive straight ahead.

5. Step 3a: 1-Sensor Line Following

BANG-BANG / EDGE TRACKING

- Tracks the **boundary edge** between light and dark surfaces using 1 photo/color sensor.



- $Ref < Th$ (On black) → Steer outside (Turn Left).
- $Ref \geq Th$ (On white) → Steer inside (Turn Right).
- **Control Characteristic:** 2-state discrete bang-bang controller; causes high-frequency zigzag oscillation along line edge.

6. Reactive Control Summary

Stage	Sensor Used	Behavior Pattern
Step 1	Touch Switch	Emergency reflex backoff
Step 2	Touch + IR/Dist	Layered priority avoidance
Step 3a	Color/Light	1-Sensor edge tracking

EXAM HIGHLIGHTS: LECTURE 04

- **EV3 vs NXT/RCX:** EV3 introduced Linux OS, ARM9 @ 300MHz, daisy-chaining, USB host, & 4th motor port.
- **1-Sensor Line Following:** Always tracks an **edge** (boundary transition), never the centerline itself.
- **Priority Arbitration:** Safety/impact reflexes always take precedence over non-contact navigation.